

Jallikattu

Jallikattu is a traditional sport that is celebrated during the harvest festival of Pongal and usually falls on January 15-16. Districts like Madurai, Pudukottai, Tiruchirappalli, and Thanjavur bring extra energy to Pongal festivities as they play host to the historically significant sport. The origins of the sport can be traced back to 2,000 years.

Jallikattu is played on the occasion of Mattu Pongal. "Jalli" refers to the silver and gold coins used in payment, whereas "kattu" means package. Someone releases a bull into the crowd, and the winner takes all the money (or flags) tied to the bull's horns. Participants in the sport attempt to slow the animal down by grabbing onto its hump and hold it for as long as they can.

The bulls used in the sport are the traditional Pulikulam or Kangayam breeds. The winning bulls of the event are the most sought after and expensive on the market. The National Museum in Delhi preserves a seal from the Indus Valley Civilization which depicts the sport.



International Balloon Festival

A major highlight of Tamil Nadu's festival calendar is the Tamil Nadu International Balloon Festival, now in its eighth edition. During the three-day festival, being held from 13 to 15 January at Pollachi, teams from over eight countries will participate by flying their unique and colourful hot-air balloons at the festival.

Not just a hot-air ballooning festival, TNIBF is a celebration for all ages and comes with many highlights. There's a food festival, carnival and music concerts on each day of the festival. The Balloon Festival is a spectator showcase of hot-air balloons from various countries. Hot-air balloons will be flown in the morning from 6.30am and in the evening from 4pm onwards. Limited tethered balloon rides are also available during the event from 4pm to 8pm but as hot-air balloon flying is weather dependent, prior bookings can't be made.

While the inauguration of the Balloon Festival is on January 12, the main festival days are from January 13 to 15. On the 12th, pilots from various countries will be welcomed in the presence of the Chief Guest. There will also be a Balloon Display Show for Press and Media.

Visitors can look forward to some fantastic concerts by the finest performers and bands in the evenings and fireworks and pyro show (8pm onwards) during the music concerts. Performers include the multi-genre music band Thaikkudam Bridge, Veena Virtuoso Kalaimamani Shri Rajhesh Vaidhya and power-packed musical fusion by singers Rakshitha & Anand Aravindakshan. On the last night, you can rock out with the Biggest Musical Jam where beats never stop featuring Nithyashree, Adithya RK and Sam Vishal.

The purpose of the Balloon Festival is also to make Pollachi an attractive destination for hot-air balloon rides and to introduce new and different entertainment options in Tamil Nadu for domestic tourists. Pollachi is one of Tamil Nadu's most scenic destinations, with top attractions including Topslip, Aliyar Dam, Monkey Falls and several ancient temples. Among nature reserves, visitors can experience the Anamalai Tiger Reserve, Parambikulam Wildlife Sanctuary and Chinnar Wildlife Sanctuary. The festival is sure to bring a lot of economic development related to tourism to this beautiful part of Tamil Nadu.

Tamil Nadu truly is a land of festivals and January is one of the best times to visit. So what are you waiting for?

